help in invoking the Essential Services Maintenance Act to ensure that essential banking services were not affected. Morarji promised full support. ‘Let the Bank remain closed for six months, I do not care’, he said.[23]

Work soon came to a standstill and the strike spread to all the Circles after a week. Talwar put advertisements in the papers to explain the reasonableness of the management’s stand and also addressed a communication to all the officers of the bank individually. Within two weeks, the Association started sending feelers. Talwar stuck to his stand that the management’s instructions should prevail over those of the Association. Within another week the strike was called off. The officers agreed to obey the instructions of the management while on duty and the management for its part gave an assurance that there would be no witch hunt.

An incident which occurred during the strike is worthy of mention. An officer in a Bombay Branch who had custody of cash refused to hand over the keys of the strong room. This was construed to be a criminal act and the management decided to proceed against him legally. Inexplicably, the matter got delayed and somewhere down the line, Talwar decided that criminal action against that officer may not be the best course of action. The criminal case was not pursued and the strike ended soon after. The matter of the officers’ pay scales remained and Talwar after consultations with the Association, got the matter cleared from Y.B. Chavan who had become Finance Minister after Morarji. When the office bearers of the Association called on Chavan to thank him he told them: ‘What you will fight for your officers, your Chairman can do it better.’[24]

However, Talwar’s relationship with his own senior management was often strained. He had his set of favourites whom he looked upon kindly. Often these were junior officers in whom Talwar saw promise and wished to nurture. He took personal interest in officers who he thought had the potential to make rapid progress; he called them for discussions, often over the heads of their superiors. This upset the senior managers, who used to a strict hierarchy, were unhappy with the importance given to those under them. Talwar’s ability to spot talent and to nurture it was well-known in the bank. Vaghul observes, ‘The young officers in the Bank got attracted to him because of his charisma and accessibility and he reciprocated this whenever he spotted characteristics which appealed to him.’[25] Vaghul says that the